

RANA ABDULLAH

Children of Pain

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I

Act 1

<https://www.avclub.com/stockholm-swooning-22-films-where-women-fall-in-love-w-1798228633>

For Movies

<https://www.buzzfeed.com/matthewhuff/complicated-father-child-relationship-movies>

1

Ordinary World

As I traversed through life, it felt as though I had become lost within a labyrinthine world, trapped within the intricate riddles of love. With each attempt to decipher its complexities, I only found myself sinking deeper into its depths, until one day, I stumbled upon the exit. However, this discovery came at a great cost, stripping me of my innocence and pride. An unfamiliar sensation left me yearning for someone so deeply that it consumed my entire being. This experience had a profound impact on my life, as I began to long for something that I had never before experienced. It was a journey that tested my pride and everything I had stood for, leaving me to ponder the direction of my life and the choices that lay ahead.

18/02/2019

It was a beautiful holiday. I had an idea for my next artwork. In order to find inspiration, I headed outside towards a cafe. As I entered, I was greeted with the rich aroma of freshly brewed coffee and the soft hum of chatter from patrons. The decor was cosy and inviting, with warm lighting and comfortable seating arrangements. I sat at a small table near the window, my face was illuminated by the natural light pouring in. I gazed outside, watching the tree. The atmosphere is relaxed and peaceful, making it the perfect spot for someone looking to unwind and create an inspiring piece of art. I was trying to create a series of artworks for my portfolio because despite applying for countless jobs, I never got any offers. I was doing some small-level online

jobs to pay my bills. Just like the flying birds outside, I come to the ground to pick up small bits of food. I was earning enough but still, I was lacking a key ingredient in my artwork that I couldn't seem to find, even though I worked for hours.

Call to Adventure

Lost in my thoughts, I suddenly heard the door open, and a woman entered. Her long hair obscured the sunlight and created beautiful god rays around her. As I saw her face, one side of her face was badly burnt, which initially made me feel a little scared. But despite this, I couldn't help but notice how pretty she was. She ordered a coffee and scanned the cafe for a place to sit. The only available seat was across from me, so she came and sat down.

As I continued to sketch, I felt her eyes gazing at me, studying my every movement. I did my best to ignore her, but she started talking to me. 'I've only ever attracted playboys my entire life,' she said. Her words caught me off guard, and I was confused about where this conversation was going. 'What do you mean?' I asked. She explained that despite her disfigurement, she had still managed to attract men. Then, without warning, she asked me if I had ever been with a woman. I hesitated for a moment before lying and saying that I had. The truth was, I was 29 years old and had never even touched a woman before.

As we continued to talk, she opened up about her past relationship, which had ended because her ex had asked her to become his second wife. Despite her love for him, she refused to become a second wife and they ultimately parted ways. She revealed that he had obtained his English citizenship and they had grown apart. Although her disfigurement had sometimes made her feel insecure, she assured me that she had moved on from the relationship

and was now living on her own terms.

Suddenly, the waitress called out her order. She leaned close to me, whispering in my ear, 'This is just between you and me. I haven't told anyone.' She then leaned back, grabbed her coffee, and told me, 'I'll see you next time. Don't go getting a girlfriend just yet.' With a smile, she left the shop, leaving me stunned and motionless. I was confused, the ideas for my artwork all faded away. I tried to think more, but her words covered my thoughts like black clouds on a rainy day.

When I returned to my apartment, I sat down at my desk and pulled out my notebook. I hadn't written anything in a while, but this strange encounter inspired me to write about her. Her story was one of resilience and strength, and I knew it would make a great addition to my book.

3

Refusal of the Call

I had fallen in love once, but after some harsh experiences, I had become hesitant to pursue any romantic relationships. I poured my heart and soul into my artwork, dedicating all my time and energy to perfecting my craft. It was my way of escaping the pain of past relationships and the fear of getting hurt again. In many ways, my art became my refuge, and I found solace in the creative process. Despite this, I couldn't help but wonder if I would ever find love again, or if I would be destined to live a life of solitude.

20/03/2019

I don't write regularly, but rather when something significant occurs in my life, drawing upon my past experiences.

A few days had passed since I last saw the woman with the half-burned face at the cafe, and she still hadn't returned. Despite my disappointment, I continued to visit the cafe daily, hoping to see her again. She didn't tell me her name or phone number and I was too hesitant to ask.

Usually, I create artwork with various bodybuilder poses which I learned during my art classes. But today, I had a bold idea. I never had this kind of idea before. I saw this in my sleep and when I woke up I wanted to create this. I was missing her and during that pain, I imagined my pain as an orb of light. I came to the cafe and started drawing. I created an artwork of a man standing

on a rocky surface with one of his arms reaching up as if trying to carry the orb of light. With pain, he was gazing at the ground. His face was contorted with pain, and it was clear that he didn't have enough strength to constantly catch the light. I finalized the artwork and posted it online. This artwork really helped me reduce the pain. Later today, I was surprised to see that it received the most likes of any of my recent pieces. I'm not the most creative artist and I don't try to think too hard about my work, but I was grateful for the positive reactions from my audience. These reactions were enough to put a smile on my face and motivate me to continue pursuing my art, even in the absence of the woman whose weirdness had inspired me. I felt a glimpse of the thing, that orb of light which was missing in my artwork.

Meeting the Mentor

21/03/2019

In a matter of a few weeks, I completely forgot about that woman. The level of creativity had gone to its initial level. I couldn't think of any great ideas. I watched many artists, but still, I couldn't create a piece of art which could catch an eye. I came back to where I was before.

My eyes are always on the ground while walking. I am shy and usually don't watch people. I was walking towards my usual cafe and then I saw a half-made painting of a woman on the floor. There was a homeless old man painting on a piece of paper. I was curious and walked towards him. I was amazed at how big it was and how much detailed. I sat beside him, and observe him making this painting. His eyes were red and his hands were shaking but he was completely focused on making the drawing. Suddenly he stopped. He wiped his hands and asked me, "Are you OK, boy?" I was amazed and told him that he had an astonishing talent. He replied, "She was my wife, and I still miss her", he continued, "She died while giving birth". I said, "I am sorry to hear that". He gazed at the sky and replied, "Ah! Don't be. She is happy wherever she is". I asked him, "What inspires you even though she died." He looked me in my eyes and replied, "My son, love is like a bitter fruit - it may not be the easiest to swallow, but those who dare to taste it will discover a depth of flavour that is unparalleled". I was surprised. He held my hand and told me, "You have the hands of an artist, don't waste your life in a confined room. Discover nature,

and you will find your love”. Suddenly it started raining and I ran towards the cafe.

While sitting in the cafe, I was thinking about what the old man was saying. I was trying to create an artwork, sitting in a small cafe. I think I should go out and watch nature for inspiration. I waited till the weather was better and head towards a park nearby.

So, I decided to take inspiration from nature. I wanted to draw some plants, landscapes and some nature. Although it was different from my usual genre, it might help me draw something new. As I sat on a bench, I heard some strange noises coming from a woman nearby. To my surprise, it was the same woman from the coffee shop, doing some bizarre exercises. Our eyes met, and she began running towards me.

II

Act 2

5

Crossing the First Threshold

She recognized me from the coffee shop and appeared to be excited to see me. After exchanging pleasantries, she inquired about what I was doing. When she noticed my sketchbook, she grabbed my sketchbook and started complementing it. We got talking, and she revealed that people are staring at her with lustful eyes, causing her discomfort. She made it clear that she believed in the importance of men respecting women and giving them their space.

I couldn't resist responding to her statement, pointing out that she was exercising in public, and people would naturally look her way. My observation took her by surprise, and she remarked, "Ah! So you spoke back, after all."

As we spoke, she asked if I could sketch her. Initially hesitant, as I dislike live portraits. She insisted and eventually, I agreed and suggested we schedule a time. Just before leaving, she abruptly asked for my phone and quickly jotted down her number. "I have to go now," she said and then darted off. My heart raced as I watched her run away, leaving me seated and wondering what my next move should be.

Despite the unusual encounter, I took it as a positive sign that she was interested in getting to know me better. I was eager to learn more about her past and continue our intriguing conversation. I completely forgot about making the artwork and just watched her running away.

As soon as I arrived home today, a text message popped up on my phone - it

was from her. I couldn't believe how fast she was! She responded with a quick "OK, when can we meet?" which caught me off-guard.

I continued the conversation and asked more about her. She mentioned that she studied accounts and didn't know much about art, but she loved watching anime, which is common between us - particularly 7 Deadly Sins on Netflix. To my surprise, she even suggested that we watch the Transformers movie together, which I thought was a great idea.

Despite her being slightly older than me, she mentioned that we had a lot in common, which made me feel good about our connection. She told me more about her past. Little did I know that her past relationship had left her with emotional scars that she was still struggling to overcome. Her ex's request for a second wife had deeply hurt her, and it had taken a toll on her mental health. Despite telling me that she was over that relationship, it was clear that she was dealing with some kind of psychological disorder as a result of her trauma.

22/03/2019

Although I don't write regularly, I have decided to make a commitment to write as much as possible starting today. As an artist, I often feel like I am below average, but I am determined to create amazing artwork that will allow me to pursue a career as a concept artist. However, I often struggle with my education and a lack of creativity, which can lessen my chances of becoming a great concept artist.

In an attempt to express my feelings, I decided to write her some poetry. I wrote poetry when I was little. But this time, the more I think about her, the more words in a musical way come to my mind.

The first poem was about a solitary soul standing in a field of yellow and gold, feeling lost yet grateful for the quiet space where he could find solace.

In a field of yellow and gold
I stand alone, my heart cold
As the wind whispers through the grass
And the sun beats down on my face

I am but a solitary soul
In this vast and endless expanse
Of golden fields and bright sunshine
That I cannot seem to understand
I am lost in thought and reverie
As I wander through the endless sea
Of waving grass and shining light
That stretches out before me
But even as the world spins on
I am left with just my thoughts
In this lonely field of yellow
Where I am but a mere dot
Yet even as I stand alone
I am grateful for this quiet space
Where I can find some solace
In this beautiful, golden place

The second poem was about a man with a dream of creating art but who was torn between the demands of life and his true passion.

A man with a dream, a dream of art
To create and to express, to play a part
In the world of colour and form and design
But life's demands, they intertwine
He works a job, a job that pays
To feed his family, to keep them safe
But at night, when the day is done
He picks up his tablet, his pen, and run
For in his heart, he knows he must
Create and explore, he cannot rust
His soul craves beauty and the fire
That only art can truly inspire
So he paints, he writes, in the hours late
Hoping one day, his dream he'll sate

He'll leave the job, the job that pays
To follow his heart, to spend his days
Creating art, his true love and desire
No longer torn, no longer tired
He'll dance with the muse, he'll sing with the breeze
A true artist at last, with his family at peace

In response, she sent me a poem that she wants me to play when she dies. Expressing her inner thoughts of death and loneliness. However, amidst all the poetry and conversations, she also shared with me her condition called cyclothymia. Learning about her struggles with mood swings and emotional instability made me realize how strong she was to endure it all.

23/03/2019

She replied, "Your words are so beautiful and touching. I wish we could have met earlier. But let's not lose hope, we'll meet soon. And when we do, I want to hear more of your poetry. Your words have a way of soothing my heart and bringing peace to my soul."

I felt a sense of joy and warmth in my heart upon reading her message. I wrote,

She was a woman of great allure,
A spirit bright, a heart so pure,
Her words were kind, her thoughts so deep,
A soul I longed to meet and keep.
We spoke of life, of love and pain,
Of hopes and dreams that still remain,
And though we talked from far away,
My heart was near, with her to stay.
But distance proved a stubborn foe,
And kept us from the chance to know,
The touch of skin, the warmth of breath,
The closeness of two hearts in step.

CROSSING THE FIRST THRESHOLD

She was in town, so close to me,
But fate conspired, it wasn't meant to be,
For though we longed to finally meet,
Circumstances meant we had to retreat.
Distance may keep us physically apart,
But our love and friendship will never depart,
And one day soon, we'll make it right,
And meet in person, under the shining light.

Test, Allies, Enemies

24/03/2019

We continued to chat on social media, and she shared her Instagram handle with me, though she admitted that she wasn't very active on social media. During our conversations, she told me about her family, including her dad who is currently serving a sentence in jail.

She shared the painful story of her family history - her dad was a drug addict who would come home and fight with her mother. After a few hours of fighting, he would beat her mother and then fall asleep. It was a stressful and traumatic childhood, but her mother never reported the beatings to the authorities. Instead, she held onto the harmful belief that if her husband didn't beat her, it meant he didn't love her.

These outdated ideas were tearing apart the future of this young girl. She was the only child and often witnessed her father bring other women to their home, causing fights with her mother. Despite everything, her mother never left her father, always holding onto the hope that he would return to his former self. Sometimes, when she made mistakes, her father would send her to her room and make her wait for hours, dreading the punishment she knew was coming. This was an incredibly traumatizing experience for her, and it left deep emotional scars.

25/03/2019

She told me about her childhood memory,

“When I was young, I dreamt about my father taking us to the park. We would have a picnic and we enjoy playing games. We would do fishing. If my dreams came true, those days would be so much fun and full of laughter.” But my father was not like that. He was an abusive alcoholic and my mother was a dreamer.

I wrote poetry about what would happen if her dreams come true,
Hand in hand, we walked towards the stream,
My dad and I, a childhood dream,
The sun was shining, the birds did sing,
As we cast our lines and watched them bring,
A rainbow trout, with shiny skin,
A memory cherished, deep within.

Last we talked on **27/03/2019** and then she went offline. I was missing her. I enjoyed talking to her.

She texted back on **06/04/2019**

She informed me that she had been unwell and preoccupied with other obligations. She had contracted the flu and was dealing with the effects of her cyclothymia, which had caused a delay of approximately one week before she could respond to my previous message.

07/04/2019

We had a conversation about pets, during which I shared with her my first love story and how I used to wander the streets in search of my lover’s home. I told her how I was caught by my teacher, and after a few days, I finally managed to give her a love letter. However, her brothers found it and beat me up. I reminisced about how I used to wait for her text messages and cry myself to sleep at night.

She responded by telling me that such a love is called “Puppy Love” and it

prepares you for real love. She also empathized with me, saying that I have had bad luck with love so far.

As we continued to talk, I opened up about all of my past experiences. I shared about my university love. We decided to make the final year project together and how in the end, the girl changed the final year project group and broke up with me. Because she thought I am not very good at studies. But in the end, I did the project alone and got the best grades.

Another story of an artist. We fell in love because we had a lot in common. We met and after that, I sent her picture to my family. Our families started conversations about marriage and then one day she called me and told me that she is not ready to get married and she need some space.

She, in turn, shared that she met her ex-husband in the town, but he left her because she was unable to bear a child for him. She told me that it was his problem but he couldn't accept it.

She also shared that her mother had passed away and she takes care of her grave. I told her that next time I will join her as well.

At some point during our conversation, she opened up about the last thing which was the connection between her and her husband was a pet. Her husband loved it but he could not take proper care. So she took the pet with her. The pet was a cat named Vitreum.

12/04/2019

We hadn't spoken for a few days, and I couldn't help but wonder if she was still interested in talking to me, or if she was simply unwell. However, I didn't want to jump to any conclusions, so I decided to give her some space and wait for her to reach out to me.

I went to the park to draw and found myself lost in my thoughts. For the past four days, I had been contemplating extreme ideas for my artwork, and I was eager to put them into action. After a few hours, I created a piece that portrayed a man consumed by heartache and sorrow. His head was bowed, and he held himself tightly, conveying a sense of despair. The backdrop was a stormy sky, dark and ominous. I employed a colour scheme that emphasized

shadows and darkness, with shades of black, grey, and deep blue dominating the composition. The man was surrounded by wilted flowers and twisted, distorted love letters, symbols of the pain that had overtaken him.

I was amazed at how my painting turned out, but my excitement was short-lived. A group of teenagers had been watching me from a distance, and as I finished my work, they approached me, mocking and insulting my painting. Being socially anxious and lacking in confidence, this experience was overwhelming for me. To make matters worse, one of the boys snatched my painting and threw it on the ground. I tried to retrieve it, but one of them kicked me in the head, and I fell to the ground, struggling to breathe. It was an anxiety attack, something I had never experienced before, and I felt helpless and paralyzed.

The boys fled the scene, taking my bag with them, which contained my phone and painting tools. I tried to get up and follow them, but I lacked the energy to do so. Some people who had been watching from afar rushed to my aid, placing me on a nearby bench. My painting had been torn apart, but a kind person retrieved it and placed it on my lap. Others took photos and videos, asking if I was okay. Grateful for their help, I assured them that I would be fine.

A man from the crowd went after the teenagers and was able to retrieve my bag, although my phone was stolen. I managed to make it home, feeling dirty and exhausted. I changed my clothes and collapsed on my bed, trying to recover from the traumatic experience.

Just as I was drifting off to sleep, I received a text message from her. I mustered up the energy to tell her that I wasn't feeling well, and she called me not once, but three times to check up on me. Her words were soothing, and she offered me unwavering support. She even asked if I wanted to talk, which I appreciated immensely. Her kindness and concern made me feel better, and I was grateful to have her in my life.

13/04/2019

She inquired about my well-being and asked how I was feeling. We arranged

to meet on Wednesday, but she made it clear that we would only meet if I felt 100% well. Our conversation lasted for two hours and she expressed her appreciation for my company. We both agreed to the plan of meeting after two days on Wednesday.

14/04/2019

Today, I was trying to finish my artwork but I could not find a really good topic. My art was a blend, and there was no meaning behind my artwork. I watched many videos for hours regarding the artwork topics but it felt like finding a needle in a haystack. I talked to her and mentioned this problem. She asked me to send her the sketch. She might be able to help me a little bit in finding a topic.

She gave me the idea to add a sadistic influence to my art. People pretend to not love this, they always try to hide but they love to hear and feel the sadistic nature of humans. Murder, blood, and human sacrifice are topics people love but never share. This is their unconscious desire to watch these barbarous things. So just try to add but don't show it too much.

She was not a book reader, how can she know these details? I was really surprised. Was she omitting her mind? She told me about her inner desire. Or she just read this somewhere but still, people always remember what they want to remember. Her past had a great influence on her. She was showing despite her hating her father, she will always have a soft spot for him. This might be the symptom of Stockholm syndrome. But I don't want to share it with her. This is just my overthinking about stuff. She might have no idea about it, but if I share, this idea might turn into reality which can cause her much more damage.

15/04/2019

She didn't show up for our planned meeting, explaining that it was the anniversary of her mother's death and she was busy cleaning her grave. She had also shared that her father, who was serving time in prison, was allowed

to visit the grave, and so she met him there. Despite being angry, she couldn't help but notice how much he had deteriorated since the last time she saw him. He was asking for forgiveness for what he had done, and though she wanted to forgive him, she couldn't bring herself to do it just yet. Despite his past abuse of her mother, she found herself starting to feel a soft spot for her father. She realized that he was old now, had quit drinking, and was trying to live a sober life.

As we spoke, it became clear that she was struggling with conflicting emotions. On the one hand, she felt anger towards her father for his past actions, but on the other hand, she couldn't ignore the fact that he seemed genuinely remorseful. We agreed to postpone our meeting until the following week, giving her some more time to sort through her feelings and decide what she wanted to do next.

17/04/2019

She wished we could watch anime together. She expressed her desire to come to me but also shared her insecurity about her face. Although we met twice, this was the first time, we were dating. Despite her concern, she was determined to make the trip and see me.

I gave her my address and she showed up in front of my door, unexpectedly and unannounced, ready to spend the night with me. Her determination was both surprising and scary. Despite the suddenness of her arrival, I couldn't help but feel a flutter of excitement at the prospect of seeing her. After all, human desire can be a powerful motivator, capable of driving us to do the seemingly impossible.

I invited her in. My heart was pounding. She was looking more pretty than usual. I think she did a little makeup to enhance her beauty. I told her to stay in the room and I started making tea for her. As I arrived in the room with tea, she was settling the room. My room was a mess. I have been a bachelor for a long time. Never needed to clean my room properly. There was a mess of papers, sketches and colours everywhere. Some sketches were hung on the

wall. I was a concept artist. There is a big monitor in the corner with a drawing tablet. An easel in the other corner with an unfinished painting on it. I hung my jacket on top of it. But as I arrive, she put everything in its place.

I offered her the tea and asked her what she loved to watch. Instantly, she told me, let's watch Death Note. I played it on the monitor and prepared the couch. We sat together and she started drinking tea. After a while, she held my arm and put her head over my shoulder. Suddenly I heard her sobbing. She shared that she can never forgive her father, for what he did to her mother. She held my arm stronger. I put my hand on her head and told her to forget he came. Live her life and don't think much about him. We were watching the anime and then she slept on my shoulder. I picked her up and put her on my bed.

18/04/2019

As she woke up, I couldn't help but notice how pretty she looked. I decided to make her some tea, and as we sat down to drink, she informed me that she had to go home and get ready for work. It was only then that she revealed to me that she worked as an accountant in a company. I was surprised that I had never asked her about her job before.

After she reached home, she messaged me to say that she had a great time and was looking forward to our next meeting. We made plans to meet again today, but before she left, she warned me not to ghost her and to be honest about my feelings if I didn't want to see her again. At that moment, I realized just how much I was falling for her. The thought of not seeing her again was unbearable, and I knew I had to be honest with her about my feelings. I couldn't believe that she had thought I might not want to see her again, as I was already looking forward to our next meeting.

I wrote poetry describing a fleeting moment of joy and completeness that I experienced in the presence of her. The moment was filled with positive sensations and emotions, and I was overwhelmed by the intensity of these feelings. I captured the essence of that moment and the desire to hold on to it forever.

The moment was fleeting, but it was real
A thrill that made my heart skip a beat
I felt alive, I had so much to feel
A moment that made my life complete
Her touch was like a dream
Her eyes, her smile, so serene
I felt her breathing, I felt her warmth
I love this moment so much
I leaned in close, my heart a drum
As I gazed into her eyes
And at that moment, all else was numb
As her presence took me by surprise
It was a moment of pure bliss
And I wanted it to last
To savour every second, every sensation
To etch it all into memory, fast
For in that moment, I felt alive
A thrill I had never known
And I never wanted to forget
This feeling that had grown
The world around me faded away
As I held her tight
And in that sweet embrace
I knew everything was right
So I held on tight, with all my might
To the memory of that moment
For it was the start of something new
Something I didn't want to miss.

As the day wore on, she returned to my home. We shared dinner and watched anime together. As the night progressed, she leaned in and rested her head on my shoulder, her touch sending shivers down my spine. I could feel her heartbeat racing as she reached out to touch my hand, sending my heart into

a frenzy. Suddenly, she held her hand over my face and turned it towards hers, and at that moment, I knew what was coming. She kissed me, and I was powerless to resist. We kissed for hours, each moment feeling more intense than the last, until we finally drifted off to sleep.

When she woke up, she turned to me with a smile and announced that we were officially a couple. The news filled her with joy, but I couldn't help but feel a twinge of uncertainty. She was camera-shy and asked repeatedly about telling my family. Despite my hesitation, I knew that I was ready to marry her on the spot - my family's opinion be damned.

I talked to my sister about my relationship. As I confided in my sister about her past relationship, I felt a sense of responsibility for her happiness. Her ex-boyfriend had callously left her for another woman, but I vowed to always take care of her and protect her heart. Our love may have started in a whirlwind of passion, but I knew that I wanted to spend the rest of my life with her.

19/04/2019

She suggested that we watch the movie for five minutes, and then we began kissing. Afterwards, she asked me if I wanted to take a walk in the city and watch some anime.

We were sitting together and then she told me a story of her past. The story of why her face was burned. She asked me if I like her with her face burned. I never thought about that. She was pretty. I always have a good time with her. We loved to spend time with each other. I just simply told her that I love her the way she looks. It's not always about looks, it's about what you give to another person. She told me that she had nightmares before I met her. Now she just sleeps over my shoulder. I don't have any nightmares when I am with you.

She continues that her face was burned when she was a kid. Her father was beating her mother and drinking. Her mother took the bottle from him and threw it. He was angry, he grabbed another bottle and smashed it over her head. Her head was bloody, she fell to the ground. He was drunk, he grabbed another bottle and pour the alcohol over her body. He took his lighter out

and threw it over her body. She was unconscious. He was cursing and talking gibberish. I was in another room. I heard the noise and rushed towards the living room. There I saw my mother's burning body and my dad was standing there crying. I saw this and tried to remove the fire but I failed. During this, my hands and face were burned. I was screaming. Hearing the noises, some neighbours rang the bell. They continuously knocked on the door and then one of the guys broke the door. He saw the burning body of my mother and I was trying to remove the fire. He rushed and grabbed me away from her. The other neighbours grabbed my father, and one of them tried to put the fire away from my mother. And one of them tried to calm me. Later, the ambulance came and took us to the hospital.

Her face was red, she was crying while telling me the story. I saw her hands which were shaking with fear of those memories. She told me only a very few people know about this and I entrust you with this secret.

Her father was sentenced to long-life imprisonment.

20/04/2019

She told me I was a good man and she felt a connection between us which would only grow stronger over time. However, she wanted to make sure that I would be able to handle the intensity of our bond once we started living together. She emphasized the importance of trust, loyalty, and respect in our relationship.

She asked me where I see myself in five years, and then shared her aspirations of being with her husband, cooking dinner, playing with their kids, and spending quality time with her partner. She told me that she felt lucky to have me in her life.

She confessed that she was falling for me. She expressed her desire to grow old together, sitting in our front garden and reminiscing about the day we first met while enjoying a cup of coffee or tea.

21/04/2019

We were sitting together on a couch with soft music playing in the back-

ground. I found myself gazing into her eyes. I always thought she was pretty but now I realized I was feeling something more. My heart was racing and my palms were sweaty.

I think she felt the change in me and she reached out to take my hand. Her touch sent shivers up in my arm and I felt a surge of emotion that I couldn't quite put into words.

For a long moment, we just sat there, holding hands and looking into each other's eyes. Then, slowly, she leaned in and brushed her lips against mine. It was a gentle, tentative kiss at first, but as we deepened it, I felt a rush of desire like I had never experienced before.

We lost ourselves in each other, exploring each other's bodies with a passion that surprised them both. In that cosy little room, we discovered a love that would last a lifetime. After a few hours, we slept in each other arms. At that moment, I knew I fell in love with her.

Approach to the Inmost Cave

22/04/2019

We were sleeping together and then she received a text from her friend that her cat died. Suddenly, her facial colour went away and she became sad. I just tried to calm her. As I didn't spend time with that cat, I didn't have any feelings but still, I tried to relax her. But she was sad. She was thinking about her ex to whom this cat belonged. All his memories took away her joy. I tried to offer her food but she refused to eat. I thought she had mixed feelings.

She was trying to reach her ex-husband to tell her the news but he was not answering. I told her to text but she said she wanted to tell him on call. Later, she rushed towards her home. I told her that I can come with her but she said no she wants to deal with this herself. She rushed without saying any goodbyes.

23/04/2019

The next day, she texted me to express that she was not ready for a relationship. I sensed that it might be because of her cat's passing, so I asked her if she would like me to come over to talk. However, she responded that she wanted to take things slowly for now. I reassured her that I would be there for her if she ever wanted to talk and that I would be patient and supportive of her

during this difficult time.

30/04/2019

Today was the hardest of all. I missed her terribly, and the pain of her absence felt overwhelming. I couldn't focus on anything else. Finally, I understood the true meaning of pain. In my desperation, I turned to smoking weed to try and ease my distress. However, the high was too intense, and my mind was flooded with hundreds of thoughts, racing from the back to the front of my consciousness.

I'm still waiting to hear from her today, but she just texted me saying that she's busy. Yesterday, she mentioned that she was with her ex-husband, working things out. Although I trust her completely and know she'll take care of herself, I can't help but worry. She confided in me that her first husband abused her, and I don't want her to experience anything like that again. Everyone keeps asking why I'm so sad and serious, but I can't help it. I can't focus on anything, and all I want to do is go home and lie on my bed and cry. I don't feel like I can share my feelings with anyone right now.

I've come to realize that she doesn't care about me as much as I care about her. Despite being available whenever she texts me, I know that I've become obsessive about her, and it's starting to take a toll on me. The pain in my heart is becoming unbearable, and I'm neglecting my family and my job. I've even let my other work pile up, creating a significant backlog. This level of pain is far worse than anything I've experienced before, even in my youth. It's starting to impact my life too much, and I know I need to find a way to move on and focus on myself.

My current behaviour is not going to help me in the future. I'm wasting my time and effort obsessing over someone who doesn't care about me in the same way. I'm ignoring the limited time that God has given me to be fruitful and productive. The pain I feel is all-consuming, and I find myself caring less and less about the world around me, even my religious beliefs are being affected. I'm starting to question whether this is really true love, or if I'm just holding onto something that isn't meant to be.

I recently sent her a poem expressing the emotions of a man who doesn't want to lose the woman he loves. Unfortunately, she seems to be exhibiting the same behaviours that her ex-husband did to her. I remember being with her when she tried to call him several times, but he ignored her. At that moment, I knew that our relationship was in trouble, and she would eventually leave me.

He sits alone with a heavy heart,
Watching the world drift apart,
For his love, his life, his guiding star,
Is ignoring him like an old scar.
He knows her past, he knows her pain,
And how her ex-husband played a game,
Of neglect and pain, and endless lies,
Leaving her alone, with broken ties.
But he's not the same, he loves her truly,
And he'll wait forever if he has to,
For her to see, to feel, to know,
That his love for her will only grow.
He dreams of holding her tight,
And kissing her under the moonlit night,
Of sharing his life, his hopes, his fears,
And wiping away her old tears.
He knows it won't be easy, it won't be fast,
To break the walls that her past has cast,
But he'll keep trying, with all his might,
To show her the love that's in his sight.
For he knows, deep down inside,
That she's the one, his soul's only guide,
And he'll do whatever it takes,
To win her heart, for his love's sake

I used to be a man who only cared about himself and his art, but my pieces lacked depth and meaning. They were simply a tool for me to show off my skills to others. I had no real understanding of what true art was. I was unable

to express my pain through my art before, as I had never experienced true emotions or felt real love.

But now, I have a weapon in the form of my pain. I can feel the flames burning in my heart and the itch in my body. My mind is in a constant state of unrest, and my eyes are out of focus. I'm no longer in control of my body, and my sleep and hunger have become erratic.

I'm counting down the seconds until she comes back to me. I want time to pass as quickly as possible so that we can be together again. This pain has become a powerful tool for me to create meaningful and emotional art, unlike anything I have ever created before.

This is the fifth time this happened to me. Am I cursed?

In my teenage, I remember waiting for a girl's text messages for what felt like an eternity. We talked for some time, but eventually, she left me. Later, while at university, I was invited to lunch by another girl, and I thought it was the perfect time to propose to her. Unfortunately, I discovered she already had a boyfriend, who later left her and she eventually married someone else. I also remember another woman, who was stunningly beautiful. However, the stress of the situation caused me to have a nervous breakdown and I asked her to wait for a month. But, unfortunately, after a month passed, she never spoke to me again. The most recent experience I had was with an artist who I thought was interested in a relationship. However, when I informed my family, the artist simply told me she was not ready for a relationship and then proceeded to block me from all forms of communication.

I don't want to experience the pain of heartbreak again. Losing in love is not something I want to go through once more. Although she has expressed uncertainty about our relationship, I will give her the time she needs. I will remain loyal to her and wait patiently. I don't want to be trapped in an endless cycle of failed relationships. Until the end of the line, I will stand by her and be there for her.

Ordeal

27/06/2019

One day, after a few months, there was a knock on my door. As I opened it, I saw her standing there. My heart raced with excitement and concern, as I wondered if she was finally back. I invited her inside and she began to cry. She shared with me that after the death of her cat, she met her ex-husband. "That man ignored me for so long, I don't know if I was obsessed with him." She expressed her feeling.

They were together for a long time, and I know there is still a strong connection between them. However, I think she overcame those feelings after meeting with him after her meeting.

Finally, during their meeting, she revealed to him that the cat was the only remaining link between them, and after that, she felt a sense of liberation from her past. She explained that they had coffee together, and then she returned home. While I had mixed feelings about this news, my desire to be with her remained unchanged.

However, she then spoke up, revealing that she had another reason for visiting me. "I need you," she said, with a calmness in her voice. Her words left me puzzled, and I asked her to explain further. I assured her that I was ready to be back with her, but instead of answering, she held my hand and burst into tears.

"I want you to come with me," she finally said, "for the burial of my father."

I was stunned to hear this news. It was not something I had anticipated. She was her father's last surviving family member. Despite the fact that she despised him, he was still her father. I couldn't imagine what she was going through. She had no family left in this world - no parents, no siblings, no one.

Reward (Seizing the Sword)

28/06/2019

After we buried his body, there was no one there except for his jail friends. It was a lonely affair, but she came to me afterwards. We sat together in silence for hours, not knowing what to say or do. But we were together and that was all that mattered. As she looked at me with a gentle smile, I couldn't help but wonder if she was just trying to comfort herself.

"I was all alone," she said, "nobody wanted to be around me or play with me, not even the teachers. It was as if I was a monster. But then I met my ex-husband in my teens and he never judged me for my appearance. We had a good life together until we found out that we couldn't have children. That's when everything changed. He started coming home late and ignoring me for days. I knew he was cheating on me but he denied it until he finally told me that he wanted a divorce because of our inability to have children. It was like I had lost my world."

Now I was in her life, but she still felt alone. She said that I had all the qualities she wanted in a partner but she still couldn't feel the hole in her heart being filled. I didn't know what to say, so I just watched her as she spoke. Finally, I took her hand and looked into her eyes. "I may not be able to fill that hole completely," I said, "but I promise you that I'll be there for you every step of the way. We can face anything together." She smiled at me and I knew

that I was exactly where I needed to be, by her side.

III

Act 3

The Road Back

As I watched her smile, I could sense the pain that lay hidden behind it. It was as if she was putting on an act for my benefit. Though she was holding my hands, they trembled slightly, revealing her inner turmoil. I could tell that she wanted to say something but was holding back. After a few minutes, the glow in her eyes slowly faded, and I sensed that she had made a decision. She asked me to leave her at her home. I was taken aback by her sudden request. We walked together in silence, with only the sound of our footsteps breaking the stillness. When we reached her home, she handed me the keys and asked me to come back tomorrow. I was left wondering what was going through her mind.

29/06/2019

The day was eerily calm with only a few clouds hovering overhead. The sun struggled to break free, casting just a handful of feeble rays upon the earth. I had been unable to sleep all night, consumed by thoughts of the day before. The need to see her was overwhelming, and I set out towards her home with a sense of urgency. My walk soon turned into a desperate run as I raced towards her door, my heart pounding in my chest.

As I approached her home, I was taken aback to see a crowd of people standing outside, all staring in the direction of the house. Panic began to set in as I frantically pushed my way through the throng, trying to get closer

to the door. That's when I saw the flashing lights – police cars and fire trucks parked outside her home. My heart skipped a beat as I realized something was very wrong.

I tried to ask the people outside what was happening, but they were all speaking at once, their voices blending together in a chaotic jumble. It was then that I caught a glimpse of her room through a window, and my heart shattered into a million pieces.

I pushed my way past the onlookers and ran towards the door, determined to reach her. But a police officer stopped me in my tracks, blocking my way with his outstretched arm.

“What's going on? Is she okay?” I pleaded, desperate for answers.

The officer looked at me sternly before replying, “There's been a fire in the building. We're still trying to determine the extent of the damage, and we don't know if anyone's hurt.”

My heart sank as I realized the gravity of the situation. All I could do was stand there, frozen in fear, praying that she would be okay. It was a nightmare that came to life, and I could only hope that it would soon be over and that she would come out of it unscathed.

Later that day, a police officer came to me and ask me about my relationship with her. Later, he told me to come along for some questions. I told them the whole story. I felt the distress on his face. He told me, “I am sorry to tell you that but she is no more”.

“I need to see her, please,” I begged, my heart breaking at the thought of her death. The officer finally relented, and I was able to rush inside the house. The sight that greeted me was horrific – she lay on the floor, her skin charred and blistered from the heat.

The guilt was overwhelming – I should have been there, I should have been with her, but instead, I was sleeping in my home. I should have come with her yesterday. The fear and worry for her well-being consumed me, leaving me feeling empty and lost.

My heart ached as I saw the pain etched on her face, her eyes closed in agony. The smell of burnt flesh filled the air.

And then one of the officers came to me. He asked me my name and told me

she left a letter for you.

“I know that you’re here with me in my final moments. I know that you’ll remember me, but I don’t want you to. My time has come, and I’m simply fulfilling my destiny. I was a work of art, a small piece carved by my father. But he left his work unfinished, and I was always meant to complete his task.

Please forgive me for any pain or hurt that I may have caused you. It was never my intention, but sometimes, life takes unexpected turns, and we find ourselves in situations beyond our control. I hope that you’ll find it in your heart to let go of any resentment and remember the good times that we shared.

I’ll be gone soon, but my memory will live on through the love that we shared. Take comfort in the fact that I’ll always be with you in spirit, watching over you and guiding you through life’s journey.

Thank you for being a part of my life and for giving me some of the happiest moments that I’ve ever known. I love you, and I’ll always carry a piece of you with me, wherever I go.”

I was not ready to read this. I knew from the beginning that she is sadistic but I never knew she could do this to herself. Her inner animal took over her and she did this to herself. I can’t forget this.

Resurrection

30/6/2019

But the bitter taste of pain lingered in my mouth long after she was gone. Every day, I woke up missing her and longing for her warm embrace.

The police called me in for more questioning, and my heart sank as I realized that her death was still under investigation. They probed me about our relationship and her father's death, and I answered each question with a heavy heart.

As I left the station, I couldn't help but feel like a suspect. The weight of the accusations hung over me like a dark cloud, and I couldn't shake the feeling that I was somehow responsible for her untimely demise.

But they eventually let me go, promising to call me in for further questioning if needed. I made my way to the cemetery to bury her body, tears streaming down my face as I said my final goodbyes.

I met with her friends, each one of them just as devastated as I was. We shared stories of her life and memories that we would cherish forever.

As I made my way back home, the emptiness inside me felt like a gaping hole. I missed her with every fibre of my being, and I knew that life would never be the same without her. But I held onto the hope that someday, somehow, we would be reunited in a better place.

As I reach home, I continue making my artwork. I was thinking about all the

time I spent with her. I sat alone in the room, surrounded by canvases and tubes of paint. The room was quiet, except for the sound of my brush strokes. I still feel the presence of her in my room.

I just lost the love of my life, and my heart was heavy with grief. But instead of letting his pain consume me, I channelled it into my art.

I picked up my brush and began to paint, each stroke representing a memory of her. The vibrant colours on my palette brought to life the love that they had shared, and the deep shadows on his canvas symbolized the darkness that now engulfed my heart.

I poured my heart and soul onto the canvas. I allowed myself to feel every emotion, every heartache, and every longing, and it all translated into the artwork.

Despite the pain, there was a sense of beauty and hope in my artwork. It was a reflection of the love that we had shared, and the hope that someday, they would be reunited in a better place.

I stood back from my canvas and gazed at my creation, a portrait of my love that was both haunting and beautiful. In the painting, my love stood at the centre, with her arms outstretched as if she were trying to protect herself from a group of people who were reaching out to grab her.

Each of the figures surrounding my love represented a different aspect of the world that had tried to take her away from me. There was a figure that represented jealousy, with green eyes, a face of a cat and a twisted smile, trying to steal my love's affection. This represented her ex-husband whose presence triggered the suicidal thoughts in her mind.

Another figure, with sharp claws and menacing glare, represented fear, trying to keep his love from taking risks and following her dreams. This was her father who took her life in her childhood, killing his own wife.

But despite the chaos surrounding her, his love stood strong and defiant in the centre of the painting. Her eyes were fierce and determined, and her expression was one of fierce determination. It was as if she were saying to the world, "I am mine, and no one can take me away from myself."

I poured all of my love and pain into the painting, using every brushstroke to convey the intensity of my emotions. I knew that my love was gone, but

through his art, he had found a way to hold onto her memory and honour the depth of our connection.

As I looked at the painting, tears streamed down my face. It was a reminder of everything that I had lost, but also of everything that I had gained. Through my art, I found a way to process my emotions and find beauty in the midst of pain. The painting was a tribute to my love, a symbol of my ability to turn my pain into something beautiful and meaningful.

After completing the portrait, I felt a sense of relief and closure. I had poured my heart and soul into the painting, using it as a way to process my emotions and to hold onto the memory of his love.

12

Return with the Elixir

29/7/2019

As I sat in the familiar surroundings of the coffee shop where I had first met her. I was scrolling through my phone. It was over a month since she died and I created the painting but I had no idea that the painting would touch so many people around the world. As soon as I shared the painting online, it quickly went viral, with millions of people sharing it and commenting on its power and beauty.

People from all walks of life reached out to me to express how much the painting had touched them. Some shared their own stories of love and loss, while others simply thanked the artist for creating such a moving work of art.

As the days went on, the painting continued to gain momentum, with news outlets and art critics around the world praising me for my talent and my ability to capture the depth of human emotion.

I was overwhelmed by the response. I had never expected that my work would reach so many people and touch so many hearts. I was grateful for the opportunity to share my pain and my love with the world, and to offer a message of hope and healing to others who were going through their own struggles.

In the end, the painting became a symbol of the power of art to transform pain into something beautiful, and of the resilience of the human spirit in the face of loss and heartbreak. I knew that I would never forget my love, but I

also knew that I had found a way to honor her memory and offer something meaningful to the world.

I couldn't help but think about creating new artwork. My mind was racing with ideas and inspiration, but then suddenly the door opened, and in walked a girl. My heart skipped a beat as I thought for a moment that it was her, but it turned out to be a stranger.

Despite the passage of years, I was still haunted by thoughts of her. It was a truly horrifying experience, feeling as though I was unable to escape her memory. I knew that I needed to move on with my life, but it was easier said than done.

But as difficult as my experience was, it paled in comparison to what she had gone through. Her own trauma had left her deeply scarred, and she was struggling to come to terms with her past. Her relationship with her father had been twisted and distorted, with a sense of destiny and fulfillment taking on an unhealthy romantic tone.

In the end, all I could do was hope that she had found peace and that she was now reunited with her mother in the afterlife. I knew that I would never forget her, but I also knew that I needed to find a way to move on and create something beautiful from my pain.